



▲ THE SACRED WATERS OF GURUDONGMAR LAKE

The Irrawaddy

Location From the eastern Himalayas to the Andaman Sea, Myanmar

This major river arises from the confluence of the N'mai and Mali rivers, both of which have their sources in Himalayan glaciers. As it bisects Myanmar (formerly Burma), the Irrawaddy flows 1,350 miles (2,170 km) through rain forest, dry forest, extensive areas of rice cultivation, and—in the delta zone—freshwater swamp forest and mangroves before entering the Andaman Sea. The river's massive sediment load extends the delta by 165 ft (50 m) each year. At peak times in the monsoon season, the

river's discharge is more than 40,000 cubic meters (1.4 million cubic feet) per second.

Gurudongmar Lake

Location The Himalayas of northern Sikkim, northeast India

Situated close to the summit of Mount Khangchen Gyao, this lake is one of the highest on Earth, at an elevation of 17,815 ft (5,430 m). Surrounded by snow-covered mountains, Gurudongmar is fed by glacial meltwater and drains into a small stream that later becomes the Teesta River. The lake is frozen in the winter months. It is considered sacred by both Buddhists and Sikhs.

Loktak Lake

Location The Manipur Valley of Manipur, northeast India

The largest freshwater lake in northeast India is best known for its *phumdis*, islands of vegetation in various stages of decomposition, some of which are inhabited. The lake has a surface area of 111 square miles (287 square km), and the largest of the *phumdis* covers 15 square miles (40 square km). Water enters and leaves the lake through the Manipur River. Discharge from the lake is restricted by a 25 ft (8 m) rocky barrier called Sugnu Hump, which reduces the river's flow.

Akiyoshi-do

Location Southwest Honshu, Japan

Akiyoshi-do is Japan's longest cave, a product of the action of water on the thick Akiyoshi Group reef limestone over hundreds of thousands of years. This cave is 6 miles (9 km) long, has a ceiling up to 260 ft (80 m) above the floor, and has a river flowing through it. There is also a beautiful complex of 500 terraced pools. Akiyoshi-do is one of more than 400 caves in the area, which is Japan's most important karst region.

Red Beach

Location Liaoning, northeast China

Large parts of the saltmarsh at the Liaohe River delta near Panjin have been colonized by a succulent halophyte (a salt-tolerant plant) called seepweed, which thrives in salty alkaline soils. During the summer months, this plant is an unremarkable green color, but it turns deep crimson from August to October, coloring a vast expanse of beach. Seepweed flats provide an important nesting location for the endangered red-crowned crane and Saunders' gull.

Qinghai Hu

Location The Qilian Mountains of Qinghai, western China

This vast saline lake is the largest in China and the most expansive mountain lake without an outlet in Central Asia. It covers

